

Chicago Tribune



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WEDNESDAY, JUNE 11, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Troubled tech firm used insider lobbyist

As Tyler Technologies tried to build business in Cook County, it turned to Jay Doherty, who was later convicted in ComEd corruption scheme

By David Jackson and A.D. Quig

This story is a collaboration between Injustice Watch and the Chicago Tribune

As a fledgling tech contractor looking to build its business in the insular world of Cook County politics, Texas-based Tyler Technolo-

gies turned to one of Illinois' most well-connected lobbyists to get the job done.

In 2016, Jay Doherty not only lobbied Chicago, Cook County and state agencies, he was also the longtime president of the City Club of Chicago, a popular nonprofit civic organization.

The dual roles granted Doherty access to the halls of power and

enabled him to easily hobnob with decision-makers such as Cook County Board President Toni Preckwinkle, who regularly appeared at the club's luncheons attended by hundreds of government and business leaders. He was a useful operative in the machine of longtime Illinois House Speaker Mike Madigan. And he helped fundraise and organize the instal-

lation ceremony for Supreme Court Justice Anne Burke, the wife of his longtime friend, Chicago Ald. Edward Burke.

At the time Tyler hired Doherty in 2016, there was no indication any of the Tyler executives involved knew their new man in Illinois was also corrupt.

Doherty would be convicted in 2023 of conspiracy in a scandal involving one of his other clients, Commonwealth Edison. It was part of a series of linked cases that ultimately ended Madigan's

decades-long run as speaker.

There is no direct connection between Doherty's work for ComEd and what he did for Tyler. Unlike Tyler's efforts seeking contract opportunities, the ComEd case detailed a vast criminal scheme of bribery and influence peddling as part of the utility's efforts to get legislation passed.

But interviews and records about Doherty's work for Tyler and details from his 2023 trial reveal

Turn to Lobbyist, Page 2



Agricultural workers in the U.S. on H-2A visas place wooden stakes in the ground for jalapeno plants at Flamm Orchards on May 29 in downstate Cobden. At peak season in June and July, Flamm Orchards employs about 90 workers from Oaxaca, Mexico. ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/TRIBUNE

AI is learning to farm

As labor costs rise, engineers are betting that computers will provide a means of meeting demands

By Karina Atkins Chicago Tribune

A century ago, orchards were the primary source of income for Parker Flamm's grandfather and many others in Cobden, a 1,000-person town in southern Illinois. Today, Flamm Orchards is one of the last standing.

"Right now, it's pretty much just us," said Flamm, a sixth-generation orchard owner whose primary customer is a Kroger distribution center in Louisville that buys their peaches and apples.

He blames the mass exodus of orchards on the challenges

CASH CROPS, HIDDEN COSTS

Reporting for this story was supported by the MIT Environmental Solutions Journalism Fellowship.

rising labor costs and a shortage of workers pose to an industry where the standard is to do everything by hand, from pruning trees and harvesting to packing and shipping.

"For every dollar we make, you can safely say that half of it goes back into labor expenses," he said.

At peak season in June and July, Flamm Orchards employs about 90 workers from Oaxaca, Mexico, with temporary visas to do agricultural work. Flamm spends tens of thousands of dollars to get the workers into the country for just a few months at a time.

The Tribune is launching a series of special reports analyzing the hurdles many farmers face in trying to be good stewards of the land as climate change intensifies. Experts preach growing a variety of crops as weather resilience and food security strategies. But Illinois farmers report that the labor demands of fruits

and vegetables and the rising cost of that labor are deterrents to growing anything but corn and soybeans.

While most produce must be handpicked from trees, vines and bushes, expansive and uniform rows of corn and soybeans cater to repetitive processes that are relatively simple to automate. Combines have been used to harvest grain and beans since the 1930s.

Engineers are betting that, one day, artificial intelligence will provide a means of meeting the more delicate labor demands of

Turn to Farming, Page 4

Chicago may force Uber, Lyft to hike driver pay

Ride-share companies say change would mean higher costs for riders

By Jake Sheridan Chicago Tribune

Ride-share companies such as Lyft and Uber could soon be forced to pay Chicago drivers more if an ordinance up for debate Thursday moves ahead, a change the companies say would cause the cost of rides to skyrocket for passengers.

Ald. Michael Rodriguez, 22nd, said his measure would make sure ride-share drivers make more than minimum wage and get paid when they wait for and drive to riders. But critics and the companies say the legislation will raise costs and could even put many drivers out of work.

"While prices have increased for years, pay for drivers has decreased," Rodriguez said. "Almost half the time, they are working, but not getting paid."

Rodriguez's ordinance would raise driver pay during rides to \$1.50 per mile and 62.5 cents per minute in July 2026. It would also establish a \$7 minimum driver payout for each trip.

The City Council's Workforce Development Committee, chaired by Rodriguez, is set to discuss and

Turn to Ride-share, Page 12

INSIDE

Playing trivia brings players together

The Chicago Stars have found trivia nights are a fun way to release the pressures of a long NWSL season — and bond. **Chicago Sports**

Flaming cheese is dramatic, delicious

Flaming saganaki sparks interest worldwide. So, where did this fiery tradition begin? Depends on whom you ask. **Food & Health**

Political cloud hangs over Army's birthday parade

Optics worry former military officials as troops deploy to LA

By Helene Cooper The New York Times

WASHINGTON — This is not the image Army officials had wanted.

While tanks, armored troop carriers and artillery systems pour into Washington for the Army's 250th birthday celebration, National Guard troops from

the Army's 79th Infantry Brigade Combat Team, supplemented by active-duty Marines, have been deployed to the streets of Los Angeles.

It is a juxtaposition that has military officials and experts concerned.

Several former defense officials said the military parade and other festivities Saturday — which is also President Donald Trump's 79th birthday — could make it appear as if the military

Turn to Parade, Page 12



Vehicles are staged Tuesday at the Pentagon in Arlington, Va., ahead of the Army's anniversary parade. WIN MCNAMEE/GETTY

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Father's Day Sunday, June 15th

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